

Flourishing In Flux: Connecting on the Things That Keep (Us) Changing

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Abstract

Transitions—between career stages, life events, project phases, and social roles—shape how researchers work, learn, grieve, and collaborate. This Meet-Up centres those liminal moments through two complementary activities: a rotating communal beadwork practice and a soundscape co-creation and listening session. Over 90 minutes, small teams engage through beadwork themes (each theme is associated with different bead types and a transition prompt) to gradually build a bead strip that documents personal and professional transitions. The group then uses a multi-media activity—voice fragments, environmental sounds, and vibrations—to surface how transitions sound, feel, and reconfigure relationships. Outputs include textile artifacts and a short soundscape collage shared with participants after the conference. We emphasize artistic and generative practices by co-creating prompts as a collective that is currently in flux both personally and professionally, and designing activities to invite multiple epistemologies into HCI practice.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

transitioning, hci, personal, growth, shifts, reflection

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1 Introduction

Being in flux means constantly changing, flowing, and is usually defined by a state of instability. This inevitable, transitory state of life is echoed in Benard Ighner's 1974 ballad "Everything Must Change"¹:

Young become the old
Mysteries do unfold
'Cause that's the way of time
Nothing and no one goes unchanged [6]

As researchers, we experience this continuous shift both professionally and personally. Professionally, this could be the end of an appointment or the beginning of a fellowship, the graduation from a degree, a change of leadership or supervision, becoming a published author, or a career transition from one industry to another. Personally, these shifts could be the loss of a loved one, moving to a new city, becoming a parent, revisiting and updating core life values, or finding a new community of friends. These spheres can, of course, intersect, for example, becoming a mother and graduating with a PhD, while also progressing to a professorship. In order to navigate these transitions, we often turn to each other, to our communities, in order to learn, share, and remember that our experiences are not isolated and entirely unique. This Meet-Up provides an opportunity for individuals to connect and engage within the liminal spaces of discomfort, inspiration, termination, sunset, and new beginnings. Due to the emotional labour that comes with complex transitional experiences, as well as the desire for alternative futures, researchers have advocated the importance of sitting with discomfort [1–3], or in the words of Haraway [4], "Staying with [our] trouble." We also continue a lineage of human-computer interaction (HCI) work that is concerned with life changes and the multitude of experiences we may have as researchers [5, 7, 8]. Although conferences like CHI are held annually, there remains an opportunity to create spaces for community building, where an environment of care through discomfort and engagement through reflection is welcome, rather than having an agenda focused on future publications and presenting position papers. It is this "throughfare" between states of being

¹First released on Quincy Jones's acclaimed 1974 album *Body Heat*.

that this meet-up is positioned. A place to foster discussions on a prevalent part of the journey through our professional and/or personal moments of flux.

2 Brief Overview

This meet-up consists of two core activities, each producing reflective conversation and a concrete output that can serve not only as a reminder of the meet-up but also of the interesting discussions the activities provoke. The first activity is a bead-making activity that takes the group through stages of transition, eventually culminating in individual beadwork creations. The second activity is an audio-based group activity that captures sounds and layers them live, creating an audio collage. There will also be a visualization that allows for multiple modes of engagement to accommodate participants with diverse abilities. After these activities have been introduced and experimented with, an open session will follow (30 minutes) during which participants can choose either of the activities to express their reflections and ideas on what it means to be in flux.

3 Beading the Boundaries

The first activity, Beading the Boundaries, consists of two main themes: Thresholds, which focuses on beginnings; Passage, concerned with loss and change; and Futures, which focuses on repair and aspiration. Each theme is accompanied by associated beads and prompts that encourage conversation, reflection, and ultimately the completion of a personal object representing the experience. Facilitators will be present to support conversation flow as necessary. In Table 1, we tabulate the details of each theme, including the beads used, an example of a prompt, and potential outcomes. Prompts do not need to be responded to orally, and participants can choose to solely bead and listen should they prefer not to share an experience. This activity is expected to last 20 minutes.

4 Capturing a Soundscape

The second activity, Capturing a Soundscape, will be a collaborative and creative one focusing on multimedia as a form of expression, accompanied by shared reflection on the previous discussions, as we look forward to the many transitory periods of our lives. Each table from the previous activity will contribute a short collection of sounds, either from the non-verbal or environmental sounds (e.g., paper crumpling, tapping, cup, outdoor ambience) or using voices, that are recorded and layered live by a facilitator into an audio collage. Participants will be provided alternative options, such as typing responses and audio alternatives for anonymization. Additionally, short audio clips will be captured during the beading activities that will be layered with reflections to illustrate the passage of time during the workshop. Vibrations of the soundscape will be paired with the audio collage. Potential prompts include: "In a few words, describe the moment you realised your role had changed" and "If this transition had a sound, what would it be?" This activity is expected to take 20 minutes.

5 Organizers

We are a group of HCI researchers who are currently entering and moving through various stages of flux in our professional and personal lives. **Jaydon Farao** and **Ajit G. Pillai** are PhD researchers at the tail-end of their journeys. **Sophia Ppali** recently graduated from her PhD programme and is navigating the space between graduate and established researcher. Similarly, **Arissa J. Sato** recently completed her postdoctoral research associate programme and is in the transitory space of job hunting and resetting. Furthermore, all authors are experienced in facilitating workshops and conversations, especially as it relates to exploring "the personal" as researchers. Arissa has conducted research to support group collaboration and is a beadwork enthusiast, while Sophia has conducted research in domains that include digital creative arts and music.

6 Community

Our meet-up will be of interest to researchers at various stages of their professional journey, but especially those navigating the in-between phases of different positions, including in their personal lives. In particular, we expect early-career researchers who are stepping into new jobs, students who are about to complete their degrees, and researchers completing and beginning projects to be key contributors to this space. Additionally, we expect this meet-up to invite illuminating and vibrant conversations on the exciting yet daunting nature of transitions. The intention being that once we depart from this meet-up, we will not only have created a community of shared experiences and challenges, but also face the future moments of flux with confidence, wisdom, and courage.

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Theme	Beads	Prompt	Outcome
A: Thresholds	Bright glass beads, small seed beads, small metallic spacer beads.	“Name a threshold you recently crossed (big or small). Place a bead for each step you remember”	Beads visually mark the steps of a beginning; capture common patterns on sticky notes.
B: Passage	Matte, darker beads (wood or matte glass), occasional found-object beads (shells, carved wood).	“Add a bead for something you let go of during a transition.”	A respectful space to acknowledge rupture; the table records themes (e.g., time lost, relationships transformed).
C: Futures	Patterned beads, metallic beads, metal charms, or distinctive beads reserved for intentions.	“Choose a few beads and name one small thing you will do to navigate the next transition. Pin it as a promise of practice.”	The final bead strip blends past/present/future and becomes a portable artifact for display or personal reminder.

Table 1: Beading the Boundaries activity breakdown including beads, prompts, and outcomes.